CHAPTER 10

SACRED BLACK

Deep sky is, of all visual impressions, the nearest akin to a feeling.

—SAMUEL TAYLOR COLERIDGE, *NOTEBOOKS* (1805)

The blue of a cloudless May morning, or the reds and oranges of a sunset at sea, have roused humans to wonder, to poetry, and to science. No matter where on Earth we live, no matter what our language, customs, or politics, we share a sky in common. Most of us *expect* that azure blue and would, for good reason, be stunned to wake up one sunrise to find a cloudless sky that was black or yellow or green. (Inhabitants of Los Angeles and Mexico City have grown accustomed to brown skies, and those of London and Seattle to gray ones—but even they still consider blue the planetary norm.)

And yet there *are* worlds with black or yellow skies, and maybe even green. The color of the sky characterizes the world. Plop me down on any planet in the Solar System; without sensing the gravity, without glimpsing the ground, let me take a quick look at the Sun and sky, and I can, I think, pretty well tell you where I am. That familiar shade of blue, interrupted here and there by fleecy white clouds, is a signature of our world. The French have an expression, *sacre-bleu!*, which translates roughly as "Good heavens!"* Literally, it means "sacred blue!" Indeed. If there ever is a true flag of Earth, this should be its color.